OpenAI Academy

ChatGPT for nonprofits



Today’s plan

01 Welcome and setup

02 Lesson 1: Prompting for nonprofit work

03 Lesson 2: Research a nonprofit decision

04 Coffee break

05 Lesson 3: Using ChatGPT Work for...work

06 Build, share, and close

Watch Try Share

See three examples.

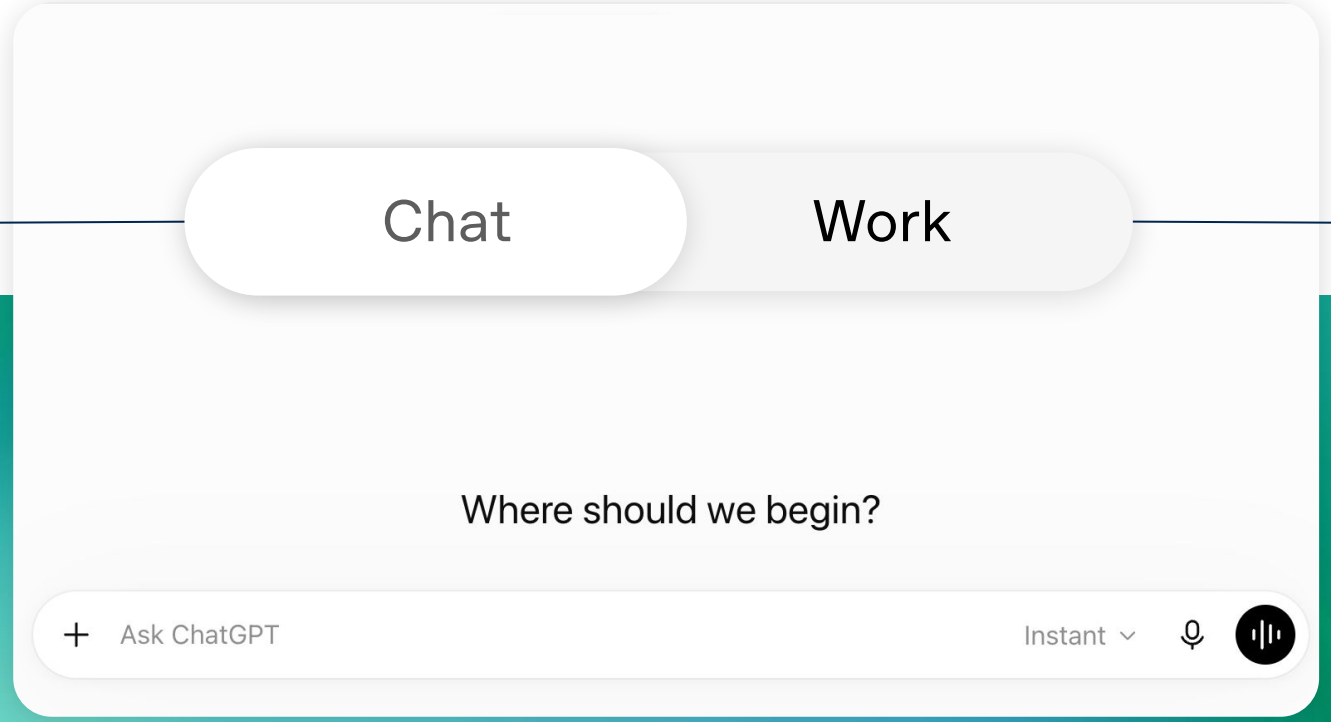
Work on what matters to your mission.

Leave with something useful you can run again.

Chat now. Work later.

Use Chat for now.

Ask questions, research, draft, and improve your prompts.



We'll return to Work.

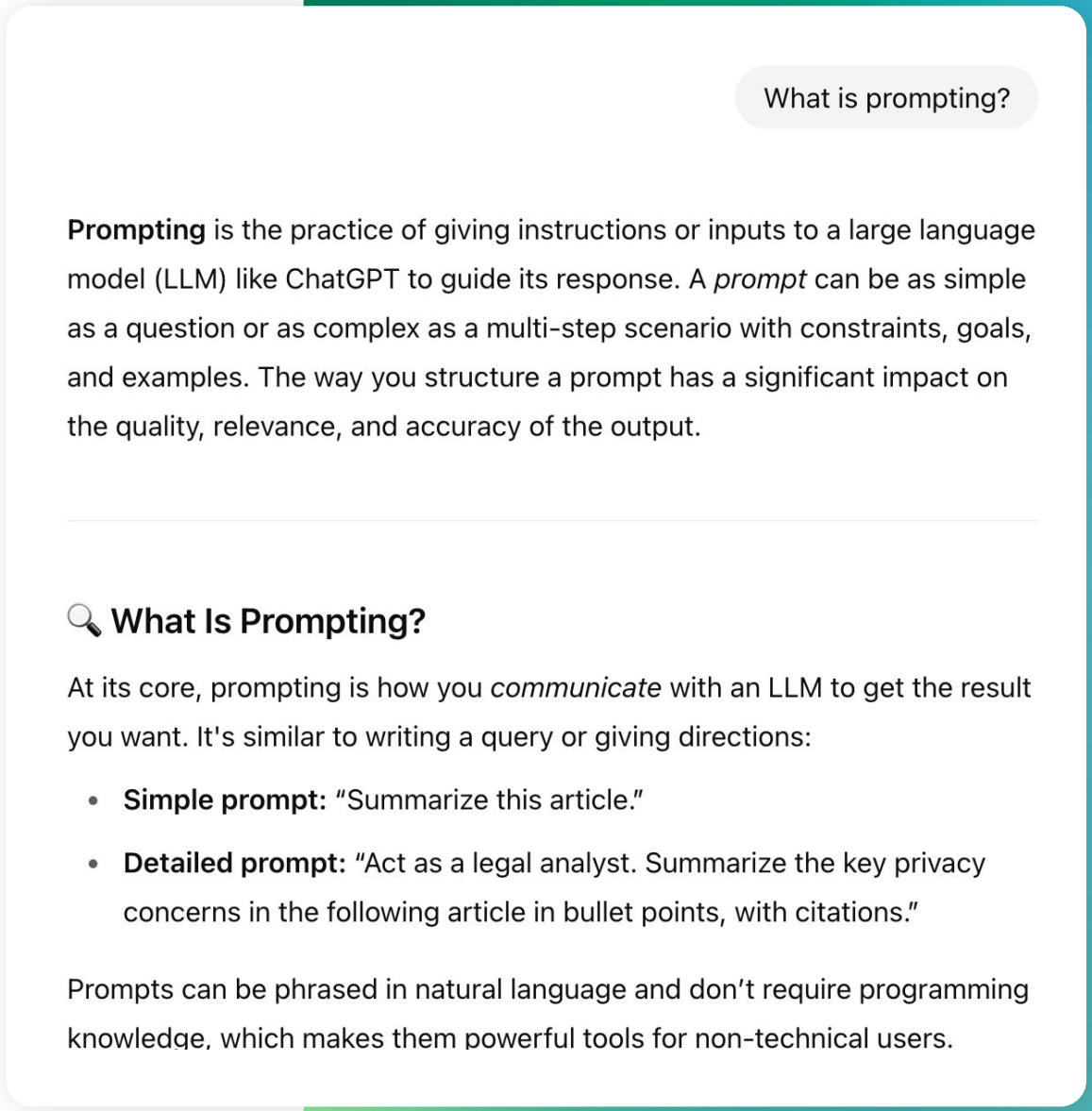
Use it later for a connected, multi-step workflow.

Lesson 1

What is a prompt?

A prompt is the question, instruction, or task you give ChatGPT.

Start in your own words and add details that help.



Lesson 1 Try

10 minutes

A basic prompt: Using ChatGPT to find and understand account settings

Ask ChatGPT:

“How do I find Data Controls in my ChatGPT settings, and what can I manage there?”

Lesson 1 Recap

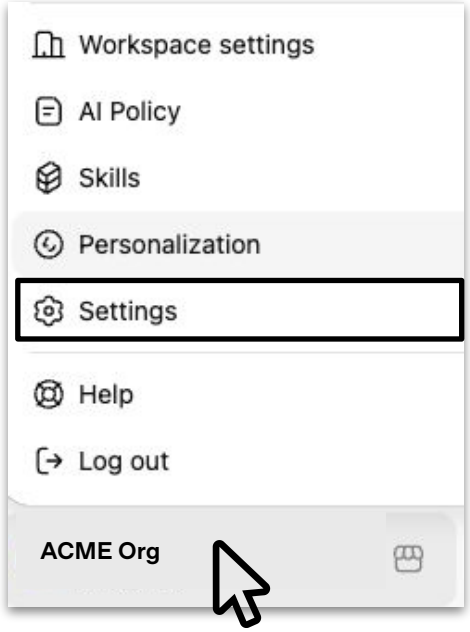
Update your data controls

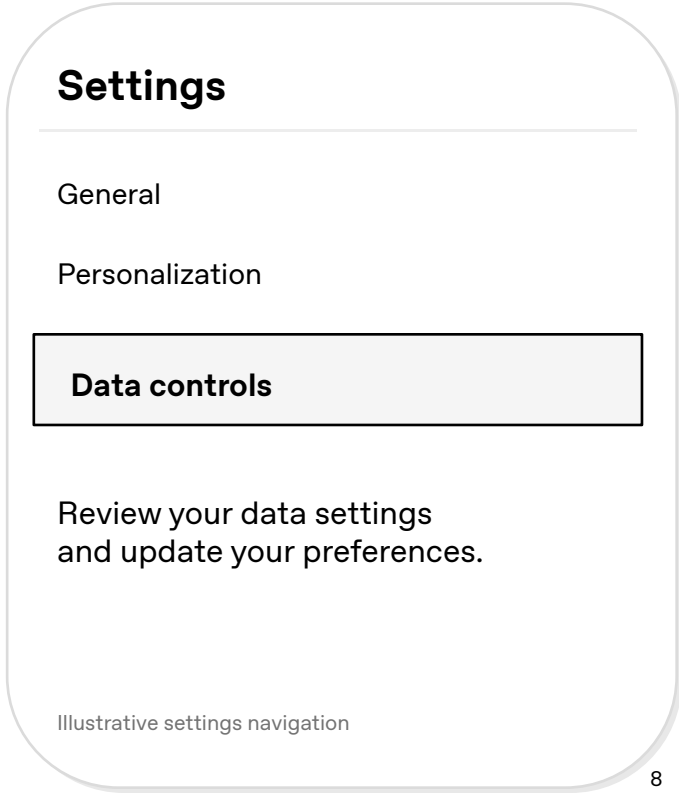
1. Go to Settings from your profile menu.

2. Select Data controls in the Settings menu.

3. Review the available options and update your preferences.

You can review and update your data controls in ChatGPT settings. Available options may vary by plan and workspace.





Illustrative settings navigation

Three ingredients of a useful prompt



Task:

What should ChatGPT do?



Context:

What should ChatGPT know?



Expectation:

What does good look like?

Lesson 1 Watch

Okay

Task

Help me write a donor update.

Better

Task + context

This is for a fictional food-access nonprofit. July facts: 1,240 grocery boxes; 410 households; 32 volunteers contributed 186 hours; two distributions moved indoors during a heat wave.

Best

Task + context + expectation

Make it warm and direct, 180–220 words. Thank donors and add a soft call to action. Use only these facts; don’t invent outcomes, quotes, or stories. Ask if a fact is missing.

Lesson 1 Try

10 minutes

Work with a partner to improve one prompt

1. Choose your own task—or borrow a nonprofit example
2. Draft the request in your own words
3. Add Task, Context, and Expectation
4. Run it, review it, and improve it once

Choose a path—or use your own

- ➔ Fundraising: draft a donor update
- ➔ Volunteer management: draft a recruitment message
- ➔ Programs: improve a participant update
- ➔ Leadership: draft a board update

Lesson 1 Recap

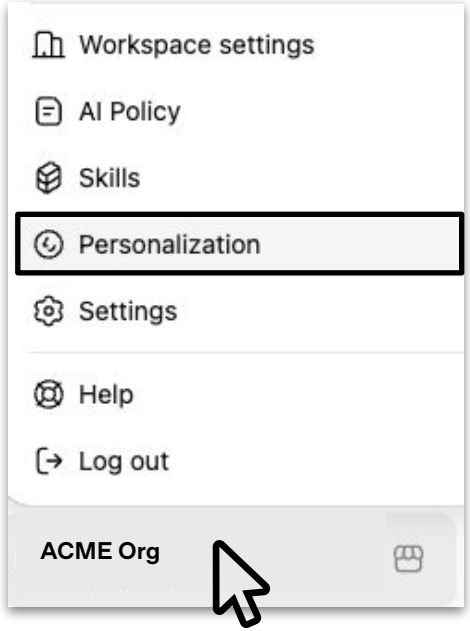
Personalize your experience

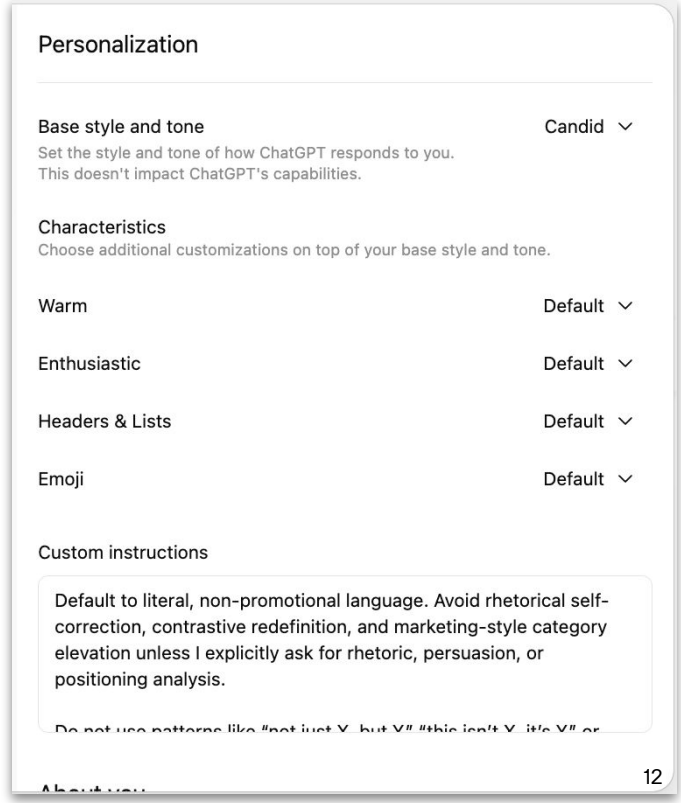
1. Go to Personalization by clicking on your profile banner.

2. Select Personalization and select your preferred style, tone and characteristics.

3. Input any custom instructions.

Memory inside of ChatGPT works thoughtfully and natively: it carries relevant context across conversations and keeps it up to date automatically.



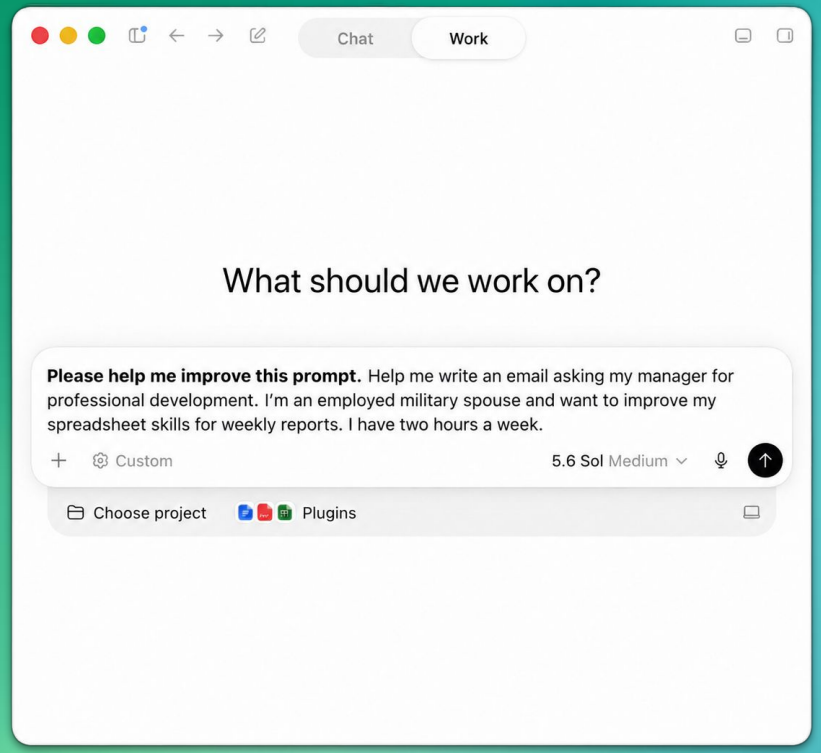


Lesson 1 Recap

Pro tip: Ask ChatGPT to improve a prompt

Ask ChatGPT to help you write and refine prompts.

- → Turn this rough idea into a stronger prompt
- → Ask me three questions to make this prompt more specific
- → Give me three different approaches before drafting



Use AI responsibly

- Keep a person responsible for important decisions
- Use only information you are allowed to share
- Follow your nonprofit, funder, partner, and platform rules
- Check sources, dates, eligibility, and consent
- Keep donor, beneficiary, volunteer, and staff details out
- Review before sending, publishing, or acting

Lesson 2

Lesson 2 Watch

Find volunteers for a Saturday program.

A nonprofit needs 20 adult volunteers in Anchorage, Alaska within 14 days. Compare practical, low-cost recruitment channels, check the sources, and draft one outreach message.

Inputs

- One volunteer need and local context
- Current public recruitment sources

Outputs

- A three-channel comparison
- Original sources checked
- One outreach message

What you'll learn

- Search and Deep Research
- Source checking
- Turning evidence into outreach
- Projects

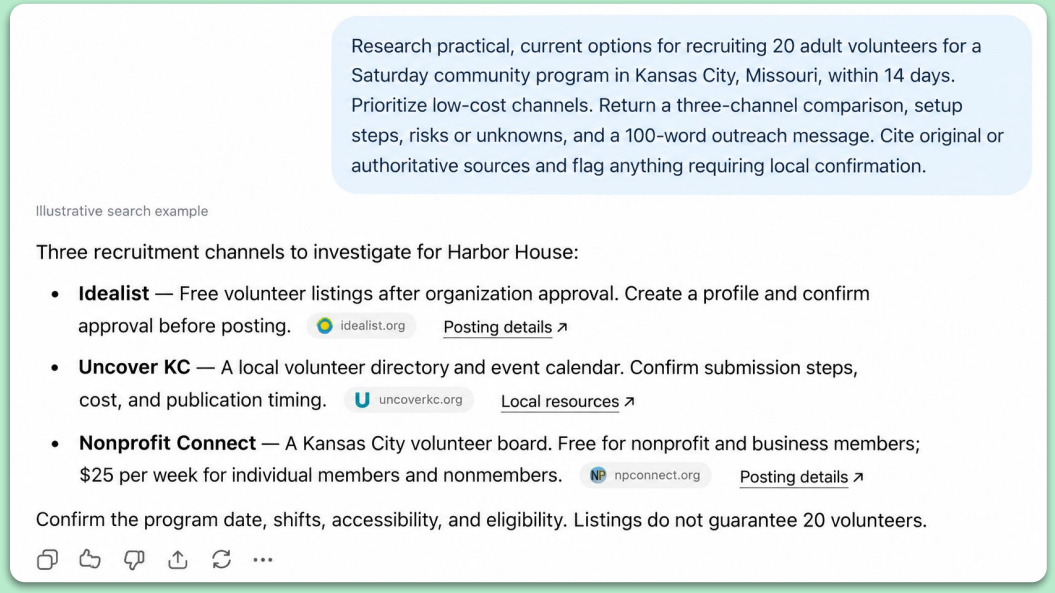
Lesson 2 Recap

Search

Find current information with sources.

How to use it

- Find current options or resources
- Open the original page and check important details
- Take note of anything that needs verification



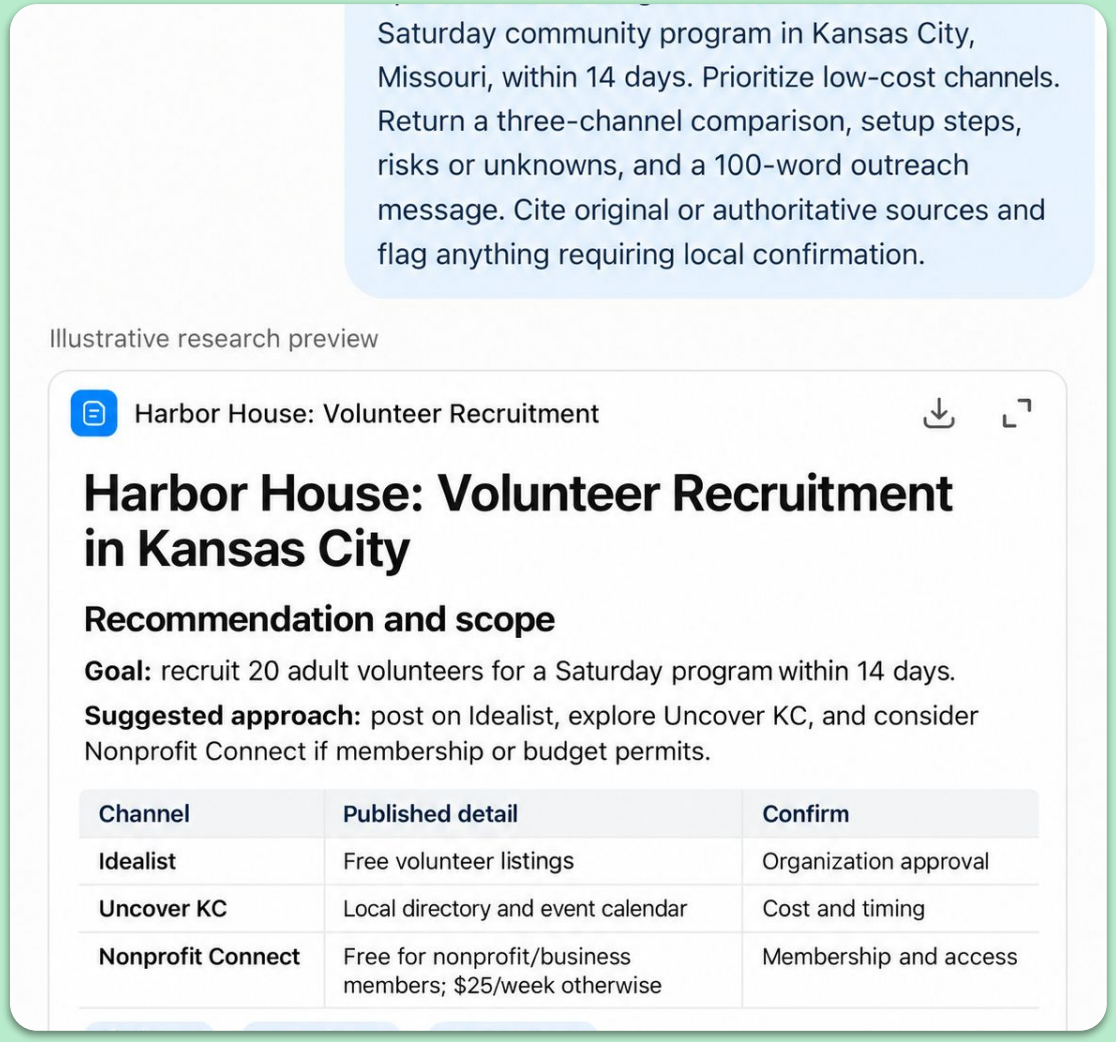
Lesson 2 Recap

Deep Research

Compare information across sources.

How to use it

- Ask one clear question
- Add useful context
- Review the sources and findings



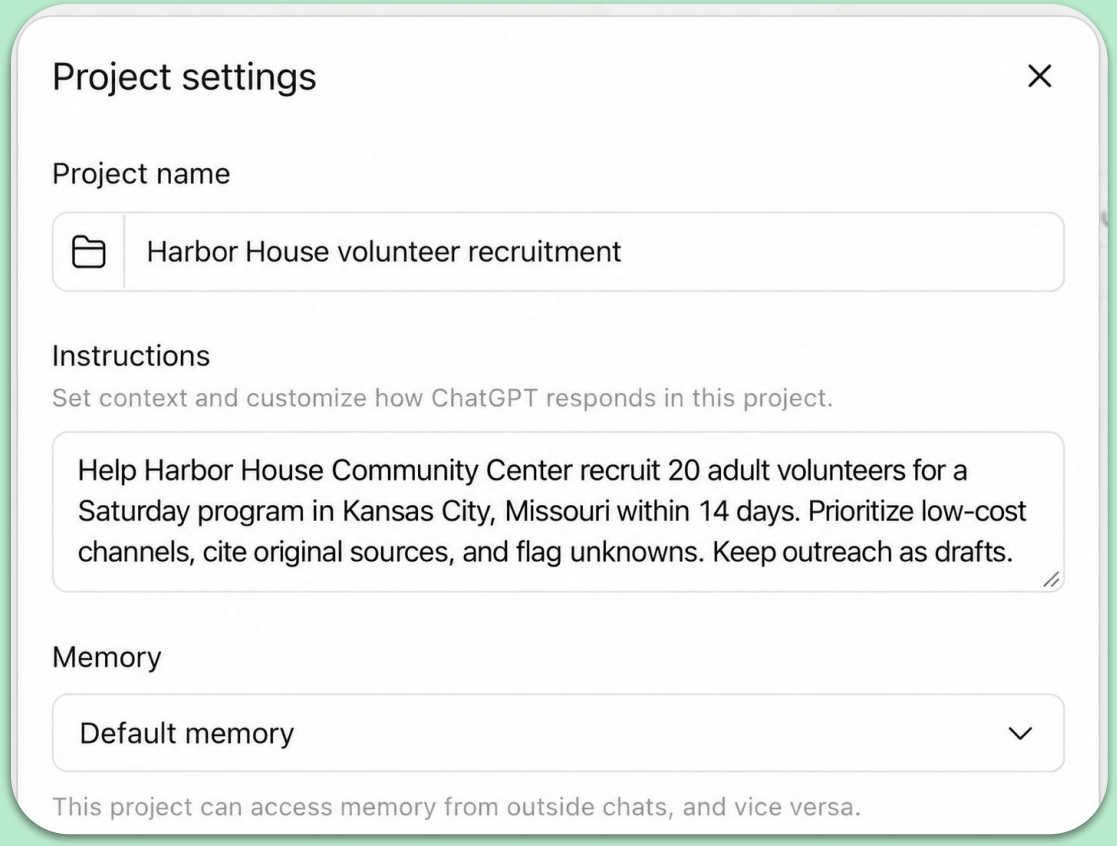
Lesson 2 Recap

Projects

Keep related chats, files, and instructions together.

How to use it

- Create a Project.
- Add approved reference material, like public guidance or a redacted plan.
- Add instructions for your goal and review steps.
- Start a new chat for a new **task**.



Lesson 2 Try

15 minutes

Research one nonprofit decision. Make it useful.

1. Start in your Project. Choose one current question.
2. Use Search. Open an original source and check the details.
3. Make a comparison, outreach message, or next-step checklist.
4. Flag what still needs checking.
5. Ready for more? Compare another source or improve the output's format.

Choose a path—or use your own

- → **Fundraising**: compare grant or donor trends.
- → **Volunteer**: compare recruitment channels.
- → **Programs**: compare local resources or practices.
- → **Leadership**: research a board or partner question.
- → Or borrow the volunteer recruitment question.

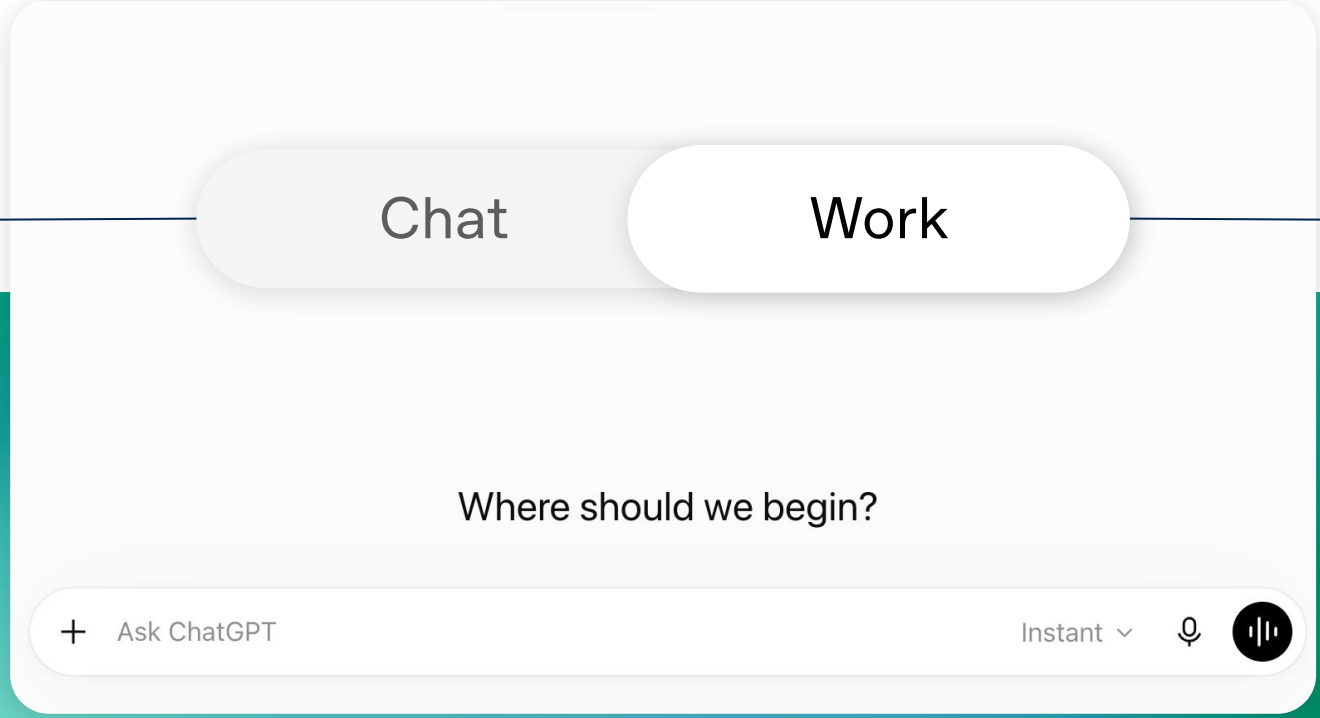
Lesson 3

Run a connected nonprofit workflow

Chat and Work: what's the difference?

Chat is your thought partner.

Research, brainstorm, draft, or explore new concepts.



Work is your agent.

Use it to gather approved context, coordinate steps, and create polished outputs.

Lesson 3 Watch

Welcome prospective volunteers

Read one volunteer-interest Sheet, save personal welcome emails as Gmail drafts, then save the method and run it each week.

Plugins	Read volunteer responses and save welcome drafts in Gmail.
Skills	Save Weekly Volunteer Welcome. Use the same method again.
Scheduled Tasks	Prepare welcome drafts every Monday. Review them before sending.

When to use **Chat**

When the task is **exploratory**, ambiguous, and conversational

When **personality** and nuance matter

When you need **quick responses** and frequent iterations

When to use **Work**

When your task requires **multi-step** execution

When you need a **polished output** such as a report, slides, or a site

When your task uses **multiple tools**, files, or applications

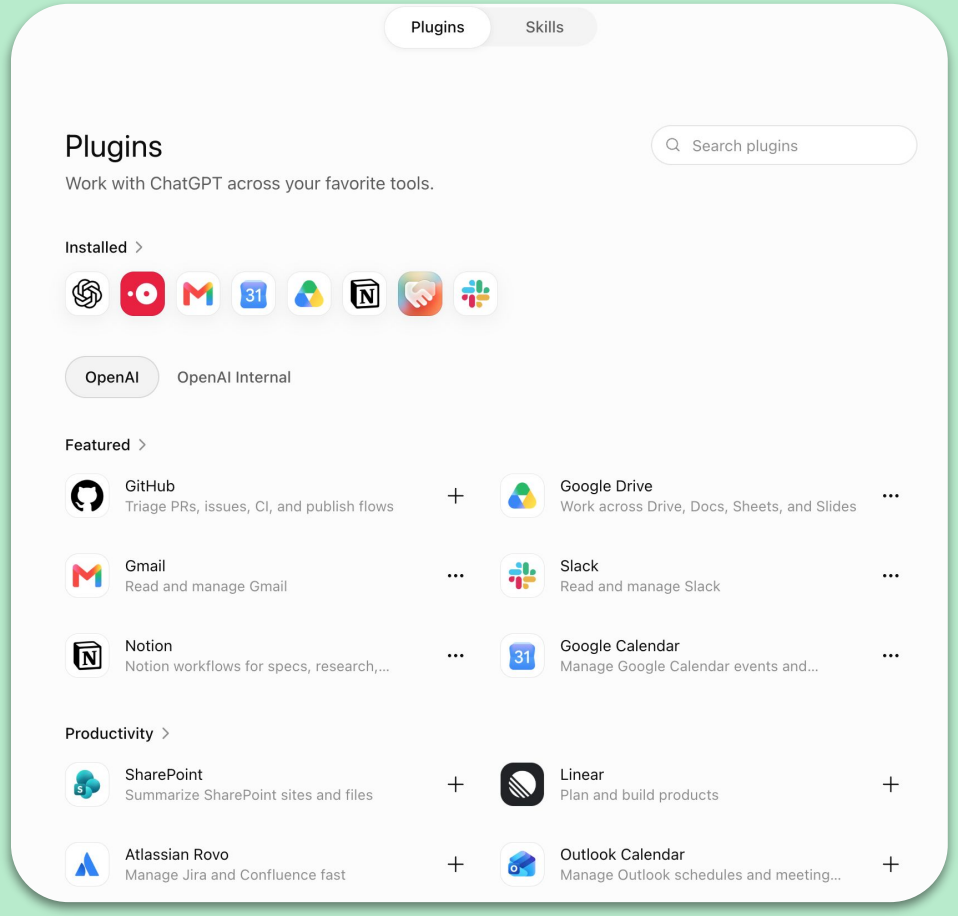
Lesson 3 Recap

Plugins

Connect approved apps so Work can read information and save work where you use it.

How to use it

1. Connect the apps you need.
2. Name the sources to use.
3. Check the information.
4. Review the result before using it.



Lesson 3 Recap

Skills

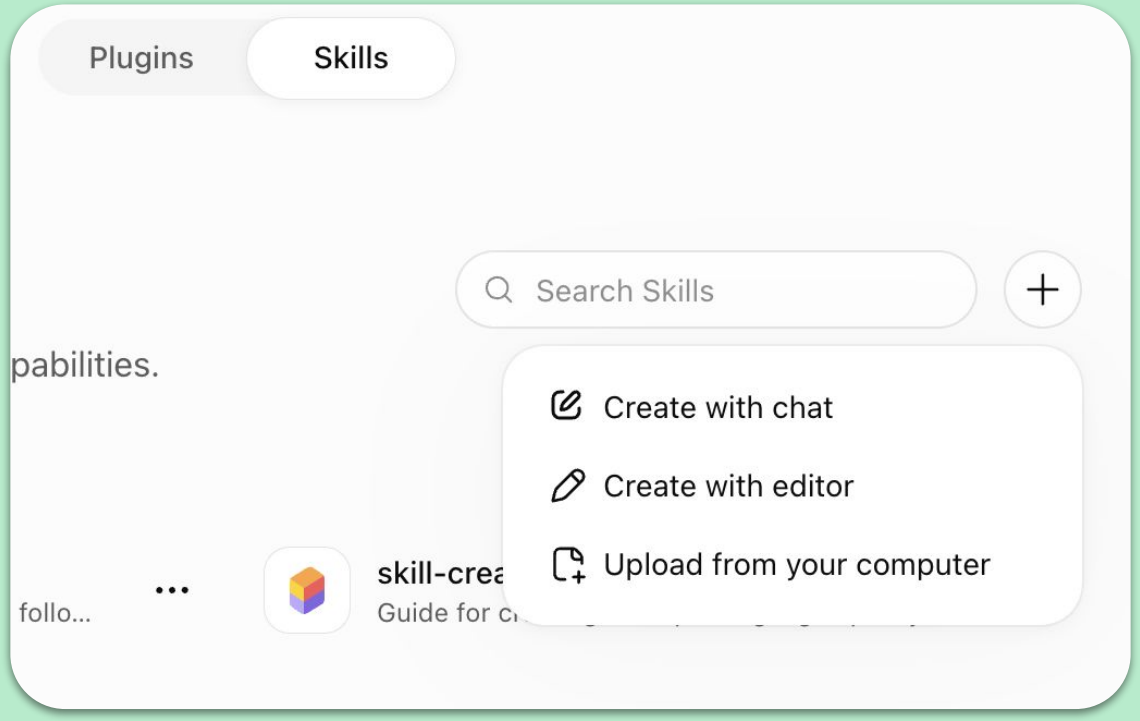
Save a repeatable way of working so ChatGPT can use it again.

How to use it

1. Start with a task that already works.
2. In Work, use Skill Creator to save the tested steps as a Skill.

Examples

- *Weekly Volunteer Welcome*
- *Volunteer follow-up*
- *Donor update*



Lesson 3 Recap

Scheduled Tasks

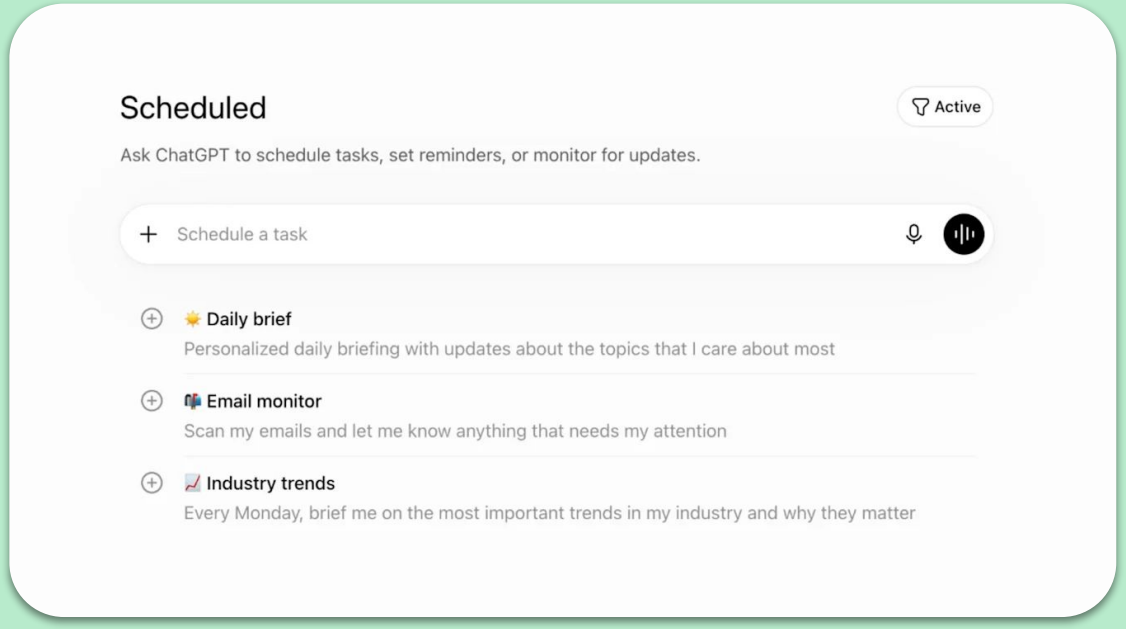
Have a tested workflow run on a schedule.

How to use it

- Choose the Skill and sources.
- Set the timing and expected output.
- Review the schedule and first result.

Examples

- Every Monday at 9 a.m. Central: prepare welcome drafts for new volunteer responses.
- Every Friday: prepare my volunteer follow-up.



Build a workflow your nonprofit can run again

Build and test

Plan	Choose one job, approved sources, and one useful output.
Build	Minimum: make one useful output and review it.
Save a Skill	Stretch: turn the tested method into a Skill.
Schedule	Final stretch: plan the cadence and review. Activate only after testing.

Choose one recurring job that matters to your role.

- **Fundraising**: prepare a donor update.
- **Volunteer**: welcome prospective volunteers.
- **Programs**: prepare an activity brief.
- **Leadership**: prepare a board or partner update.

Reuse what works

3 minutes

Projects

Keep approved context together.

Plugins and Skills

Connect approved apps. Save a tested method.

Scheduled Tasks

Have a useful workflow prepare work on your schedule.

What’s next?

Choose one workflow to use again this week.

Nonprofit Policy Builder

techimpact.org/policybuilder

A strong Computer Use Policy is essential for nonprofit organizations to protect sensitive data, ensure compliance, and promote responsible technology use across their teams.

Tech Impact's Computer Use Policy Digital Workbook tool includes four key focus areas:

